

Éti in Martinican Creole: Functions and origins of a “martinicanisme”



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Éti in Martinican Creole:

**Dé péyi *éti ki* lévé lematen bien
déli apré pasaj siklòn-an.** (c. 617)

“Two countries **which** rose up early in the morning after the cyclone’s passing.”

Éti in Martinican Creole

A corpus-based study aiming to:

- clarify and systematize findings on **ETI's functions**;
- analyze the structure **ETI KI**;
- consider possible pathways of **historical development**.



AGENDA

1. Background
2. Our corpus analysis of ETI
3. Findings: attested and new
4. Historical development
5. Future work

1. Background

- a. Martinican Creole
- b. Previous studies on ETI



a. Martinican Creole

- **French-based Creole** mostly spoken in Martinique; today a “collectivité territoriale unique”
- Under French sovereignty by 1635.
- **17th and 18th centuries:**
a prime market for enslaved people imported from the Bight of Benin, West Central Africa, and the Bight of Biafra (Geggus 2001: 137).
- **Linguistic contributions** include:
 - Manding, West Atlantic, Gbe, Yoruba, Igbo, and Bantu languages (substrate)
 - varieties of French (superstrate)



a. Martinican Creole

Sé bef-la isia pa abitié épi mouton.

PL beef-DET here NEG familiarize with sheep

“Les bœufs d'ici ne sont pas habitués aux moutons.” (Confiant 2007: 2)



SVO; preverbal
TMA particles;
no inflectional
nominal or verbal
morphology



French-based
lexicon



Post-nominal
determiners



The “bedrock” of
several offshoot
Antillean Creole
languages

E.g., Dominica,
St. Lucia, Guadeloupe

b. Previous studies on ETI

i. Locative interrogative adverb (Bernabé 1987 : 88)

Éti/Oti kay ou (ye) ?

where house POSS.2SG is ?

“Where is your house?”

ii. Perlocutory interrogative phrase

Éti ? = Sorry? Excuse me?

iii. Optional **correlative** morpheme announcing a relative pronoun, which may be overt or covert (Bernabé 1987 : 88)

Man ped liv-la (éti) ou té pwété mwen an

“I lost the book [that] you lent me.”

b. Previous studies on ETI (Librova 2021)

iii.a. Locative relative pronoun

Koté-a éti man ka alé a pa ni zèb ankò.

“The place **where** I’m going does not have zebra anymore.”

b. Object relative pronoun

Yo ka glorié di fè bagay éti ki lézot pa noz fè.

“They’re boasting about doing things **that** others dare not do.”

c. Oblique relative pronoun

Sé an moun éti lang-li toujou an travay.

“It’s someone **whose** language is always a work in progress.”

d. Subject relative pronoun

Boug-la éti ki ka rété Fòdfrans la

“The guy **who** lives in Fort-de-France.”

b. Previous studies on ETI – Origins?

Superstrate

Librova (2021) proposes:

- ❖ **Adverbial *éti*** < reduction of [w] in the morpheme *wéti*.
This morpheme is said to originate in **French *Où est-il* ?** “Where is he?”
 - **Relative *éti*** originates from **an extension of the adverbial marker** through relativization.
- ❖ **Perlocutary interrogative *Éti* ?** comes from French *plait-il* also found in other Creoles (Haitian Creole *plètil/ètil/etil*).

Substrate African languages?

E.g., Gbe, Yoruba
(Xu 2023)

3. Our corpus analysis

a. Data and methods



a. Data and methods



- News and blog articles written in Martinican Creole
- Kréyolad collection from Montray Kréyol website, published from 2004-2021
- 14k types / 280k tokens
- All occurrences of ETI were extracted – about 500+

Analysis of:

- **ETI**'s and **ETI KI**'s functions (attested and unattested)
- Syntactic context
- [$\pm$ Specific]

4. Findings

- a. Attested
- b. Additional uses of ETI:
 - i. Temporal subordinate and relativizer
 - ii. Complementizer
- c. Analysis of the combination ETI KI



a. Attested

All uses of **éti** as described in the literature, except the perlocutory ("Sorry? Excuse me?"). Examples of relative pronouns:

3a. Locative relative pronoun

Man pé ké alé pies koté **éti** yo pa ka respekté mwen ! (c. 389)

"I won't go anywhere **where** they don't respect me!"

b. Object relative pronoun

Ében sa tewminé ba Jeff asou tè Matinik **éti** i té enmen. (c.388)

"Well, it ended for Jeff on the land of Martinique **which** he loved"

c. Oblique relative pronoun

Ni an kandida **éti** papa'y té trapé an falfret Lanmanten... (c. 393)

"A candidate **whose** father had an anxiety episode in Lamentin"

d. Subject relative pronoun

Dédé palé di moun **éti** ka détounen ladémokrasi. (c. 395)

"Dédé spoke of people **who** are overturning democracy."

b. Additional uses *ETI* alone, not ETI (KI)

→ Temporal subordinating conjunction

Ni an kandida ki santi bagay-la cho, i mandé Toto (an konpè'y Gwadeloup), **éti** yo fini nonmen minis, vini bay an pal. (c.407)

"There was a candidate who saw that things were getting heated, and he asked Toto (a Guadeloupean friend), **when** they've finished naming ministers, to come give us a hand."

→ Temporal relative (≠ locative)

San fidji sé an prenses karayib an tan **éti** [...] péyi-nou an té ni an bel soukramétan dianman anlè'y. (c.35)

"San fidji is a Caribbean princess from a time **when** our land was covered in beautiful diamonds."

Sel moman **éti** nou té vréman lib sé té oswè avan nou monté dortwa.

(c.61) "The only moment **when** we were truly free was at night before heading to the dorms."

b. Additional uses

→ **Complementizer** (= *je comprends* **que**)

Man fè sé touris-la konprann **éti nou té adan an sel LIANNAJ épi Lagwadeloup, pas la té ESPLOZION Zabim éti té ka dansé WAKA. (c. 394)**

"I made the tourists understand **that** we were in one sole league with Guadeloupe, because there was Explozion Zabim that was dancing Waka."

N.B. Martinican Creole, prescriptively, does not use an overt complementizer. For now, we don't know whether c. 394 is a case of:

1. **ETI standalone**, acting as the complementizer
2. **ETI (KI)** in which **KI is covert** and **ETI a "co-complementizer"**

c. The combination ETI KI

- i. True subject relative pronoun
- ii. Ostensible “subject relative pronoun”
whose semantic essence is spatial or
temporal
- iii. Complementizer

Our data showed no examples of ETI KI functioning as a direct/indirect object pronoun.

i. True subject relative pronoun

...tout peyi kréyolopal éti ki enmen literati... (c. 419)
“...all creolophone countries **which** love literature...”

- ETI KI unambiguously replaces a subject noun
- KI carries the semantic substance
- ETI could be a discursive particle – marking style or register – or an optional ‘expletive’ (cf Bernabé 1983, 1987; Pinalie & Bernabé 1999).
- ETI has no spatial or temporal relevance.

ii. Ostensible “subject relative pronoun” but semantically spatial or temporal

- **Context?** Sentences containing the verb NI.
 - Specifically where use of **impersonal NI** ‘**there is/are**’ (existential) is possible.
 - Not necessarily lexical NI ‘have’ (possession)

Tala **éti ki ni** Jounen entènasionnal kréyol.

“That week **in which there is** (which has?) International Day of Kréyol.”

ii. Ostensible “subject relative pronoun” but semantically spatial or temporal

- Where *éti ki* appears with **impersonal NI** ‘**there is/are**’, ETI’s **locative sense** has more relevance, stronger semantic weight. ETI’s purpose as the **exponent** is much clearer and **KI is the expletive**, an analysis previously proposed by Librova (2021: 428).

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**Van rasi-tala mennen bon dézolation *éti ki* jik
atjelman *ni* moun ki malad.**

“This terrible wind brought about significant damage **to the point where** (Fr. *au point où*) **there are** people who are still suffering today.”

iii. Complementizer

- **Context?** Sentences containing the verb **NI**
 - Specifically, **impersonal NI** ‘**there is/are**’ (existential).

Yo matjé an gran jounal-la éti ki ni 27 fanm ki ja mò.

“They wrote in the major newspaper **that there were** 27 women who had already died.”

- Hypercorrection? MC, prescriptively, does not use an overt complementizer:

Man kwè __ santé’y ka dégradé jou an jou. (Confiant 2007: 14)

Je crois **que** sa santé se dégrade jour après jour.

I believe (that) his health is deteriorating day by day.

Thus, we propose the existence of multiple forms of ETI which combine with KI:

- **ETI 1 discursive/expletive + KI relative subject pronoun**
Preceding all lexical verbs, including NI 'have'
 - **ETI 2 locative/temporal relative + KI expletive**
Preceding impersonal NI
 - **ETI KI 3 complementizer**
Possibly hypercorrective
(no claims yet regarding which element is expletive)
- These forms of ETI may or may not be homonyms.

4. Historical development

a. ETI, the temporal/spatial relative



What is the source of **ETI**, the **temporal/spatial relative**?

Sel moman éti nou té vréman lib sé té oswè avan nou monté dortwa. (c.61)

"The only moment **when** we were truly free was at night before heading to the dorms.

Possible hypotheses:

1. Universal grammaticalization pathways (Librova 2021)

Interr. adverbial > relative > temporal/spatial relative

WH-words become relative pronouns in many languages
(Heine & Kuteva 2002: 251).

E.g. who/which interrogatives > relatives (QUI/QUE in French)

What is the source of **ETI, the temporal/spatial relative**?

2. Bilingual contact with French *où*

If so, when did this occur? That speakers started using ETI suggests that they treated it as an overt marker of relativity. To be determined after we study older texts (18th-19th c.).

3. From substrate languages, at the creole's inception

Query whether such patterns also exist in West African or other substrate languages. If they do, then this could clarify the potential degree of influence from French.

What is the source of **ETI, the temporal/spatial relative**?

3. Substrate languages

For example, Yoruba *tí* and Ewe *si* (inter alia) show similar patterning to MC *éti* subject/object relative (Xu 2023).

RELATIVE PRONOUNS.

Ti, the only relative pronoun, is equivalent to “who,” “that,” “which,” and “what.” It is used with the personal pronoun after it, in the nominative case; as, *Okonri tí ó kẹ iggi*, “the man he who cut wood.” *Babba tí ó bí mi*, “the father he that begat me.” *Obiri tí ó ẹun*, “the woman she who is kind.” *Kinni tí ó bọ*, “the thing it which dropped.” But in the objective case, the personal pronoun is omitted, the relative being then governed by the verb; as, *Kinni tí mọ fẹ*, “the thing which I like.” *Ille tí mọ wó*, “the house which I pulled down.”

Yoruba (Crowther 1852: 15)

Do such forms accept a temporal/spatial reading as well?

What is the source of **ETI**, the **temporal/spatial relative**?

3. Substrate languages: Ewe

(Dzablu-Kumah 2006: 135; Xu 2023)

Atí **si** mu' lá wu gbõ eve.
tree **which** fall.PST DEF kill goat two
“The tree **which** fell killed two goats.”

Xo **si** míéfle' lá lolò nùtó.
House **which** 1pl.buy.PST DEF large very
“The house **which** we bought is very large.”

Do such forms accept a temporal/spatial reading?

Martinican Creole:

Ében sa tewminé ba Jeff
asou tè Matinik **éti** i té
enmen. (c.388)

“Well, it ended for Jeff on
the land of Martinique
which he loved.”

5. Future work



Éti in Martinican Creole

- Comparison with sentences which **lack éti**
- Is éti **idiolectal**? A stylistic choice made by speakers in certain registers, speech, or writing?
 - Survey and interview native speakers
- **Substrate vs superstrate** contributions



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Thank you

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